3.1 Different Strategies

Everyone has strengths and weaknesses. You may be good at math and sports but not so great at science and card games. The trick is figuring out how to use what you've got to the best advantage.

MAIN IDEA Both the Union and the Confederacy had advantages and disadvantages, and each came up with strategies for winning the war.

STRENGTHS AND WEAKNESSES

During the Civil War, both the North and the South had strengths and weaknesses. The North had a much larger population than the South. And Union states were home to large cities, which were centers of business and industry. More than 100,000 factories were located in Union states—about five times the industrial capacity of the agrarian South.

The Union also boasted a stronger military infrastructure. It had a navy and many more ships than the South. West Point, the best military academy in the country to train leaders in the midst of war, was in the North. Many northern officers had trained there. However, the South also had talented graduates of West Point leading its soldiers. You may remember that Robert E. Lee graduated from the military academy, and so did Jefferson Davis, the Confederate president.

With its smaller numbers, the South fought the war largely on the defensive. Simply trying to defend itself seemed to be the best way to win the war, at least initially. As a result, most of the fighting took place in Confederate states. But this gave the Confederate forces a geographic advantage. They were fighting in areas they knew well, while the Union Army found itself on unfamiliar ground.

The South also used more offensive tactics to wear down the North. Confederate leaders encouraged private ship owners to intercept and capture northern merchant ships and their cargo in the Atlantic. And some southern generals planned to concentrate their forces and exert pressure on the northern capital of Washington, D.C., which bordered southern states.

MAKING A GAME PLAN

One of the renowned generals who led the Union, Winfield Scott, a hero of the Mexican-American War and the War of 1812, also had a plan. When the Civil War began, Scott was the commander-in-chief of the U.S. Army. In early 1861, he formulated a strategy he hoped would put an end to the war. His plan called for blocking Confederate ports along the Atlantic and Gulf coasts with Union warships. The North hoped to cripple the Confederate war effort and economy by preventing the delivery of weapons and halting cotton exports. Scott also proposed sending troops to gain control of the Mississippi River and capture major cities and river ports, creating divisions in the South.

Scott's massive blockade was risky. No blockade of this size had ever been tried before. There were more than 3,000 miles of coastline to block with fewer than 40 ships! Scott's idea was nicknamed the **Anaconda Plan** after a type of snake that strangles its prey. Within a week after the loss of Fort Sumter, Lincoln ordered the blockade to be carried out, and it was somewhat successful. However, many northern leaders ridiculed the plan. They wanted to take action and fight.

To counter the plan, the South tried to create a cotton shortage on the European market. The Confederacy hoped the shortage would force Great Britain and France, two major cotton consumers, to join the Confederate cause and help break up the Union blockade. The attempt backfired when both countries bought cotton from Egypt and India instead. Meanwhile, the Confederate Army engaged in terrible battles on the ground that would claim many lives and, eventually, give the South greater hope.

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SCOTT'S GREAT SNAKE

The Anaconda Plan was meant to strangle the South by cutting off all trade among southern states and allowing the Union to take control of the Mississippi River. Scott believed his plan would put an early end to the war and limit the number of casualties.



Scott's plan was never fully implemented, but a naval blockade was maintained throughout the war. The blockade succeeded in cutting off the South's resources and probably did shorten the war. But not even Scott knew how the war would develop. He guessed it would go on for two years, not four.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was General Scott's strategy for winning the war?
2. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** What geographic advantages did the South have over the North?
3. **ANALYZE VISUALS** What resources did the Anaconda Plan attempt to prevent from being traded in the South?

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